The Fee-Stack Calculator: The App I Am Building for an Agency That Shows Sellers the Fees Their Calculator Misses - Across TikTok Shop, Amazon, Etsy, and eBay

By Imtiaz Ahmad, Soft Tech Solution - a software developer and AI expert. I am building this app for an agency, and this guide is the blueprint on which I am working. It is written from the builder's side of the table: I design the systems; sellers run their businesses on them.

1. The Gap: Your Profit Calculator Only Sees Part of the Fees

Most sellers already use a profit calculator. That is exactly the problem.

The calculators sellers already have fail in three ways:

They are manual. The seller types numbers into a spreadsheet or a web form and gets a snapshot. Nobody re-types the numbers after every order, so the snapshot is a month old within a week - and pricing decisions made from a month-old snapshot are guesses.

They only see the visible fees. A calculator usually covers the platform's headline fee - the referral or transaction fee printed on the pricing page. On TikTok Shop, those visible fees are only about 10% of revenue. The other 57% - affiliate commissions, ad spend, content production, shipping, returns, operations - lives in other dashboards that the calculator never touches. So the calculator's profit number is wrong from the start, and the seller only discovers it when the payout lands.

They report after the fact. A typical calculator tells you what last month's profit was. It never stops you before you list a product at a price that loses money. By the time the report arrives, the bad price has already sold hundreds of units.

And if you sell on more than one marketplace, the gap gets worse, not better. A seller on TikTok Shop, Amazon, and Etsy at once has fees scattered across three platforms, three ads dashboards, and three returns queues - and no single calculator that sees all of them. The more marketplaces you sell on, the less your calculator knows.

That is the gap this guide closes: not with another calculator that repeats the same partial math, but with a custom application I am building for an agency - the Fee-Stack Calculator. One app, one core, and one fee module per marketplace, so every layer of cost lands in a single live margin dashboard.

2. The Custom App, Piece by Piece

The Fee-Stack Calculator is a custom web application I am building for an agency, not a generic spreadsheet. It has one shared core and one module per marketplace. Here is what goes into it, piece by piece.

The shared core - the same on every marketplace

1. Unified cost model.

Every cost, from every marketplace, is stored the same way: per order, per SKU, per marketplace, per month. Revenue, every fee layer, cost of goods, and net profit - in one model, so a SKU sold on two platforms can be compared side by side.

2. Live margin dashboard.

The headline number is not revenue. It is true margin: what the seller actually keeps. The dashboard updates as orders, fees, and ad spend change, so the number is never a month old.

3. Warn-before-you-price simulator.

Before a seller lists or reprices a product, the app runs the full stack for that marketplace against the proposed price and warns when the price loses money: "At $34, this SKU keeps $0.90 per order after all fees. At $38, it keeps $4.10." Pricing stops being a guess and becomes a decision made with the whole stack in view.

4. Cross-marketplace view.

For sellers on two or more platforms, one screen answers the question no single marketplace dashboard can: which platform actually keeps the most per order on the same product - and where should the next batch of stock go?

Module: TikTok Shop

Data source: TikTok Shop partner and seller APIs for orders, fees, and settlements, plus statement import where an API field is missing.

Fee layers it tracks: referral fees by category (fashion 8%, beauty 5%, health 6%, home 5%, electronics 3%, food 2%, baby 5%; new sellers get 2% for the first 90 days, which then jumps to the standard rate); transaction fee of $0.30 per order; payment processing of 2.0%; shipping and fulfilment (typically 8-15% of order value for products in the $20-$80 range); affiliate commissions (5-15% for open collaboration, 10-20% for targeted creators, blending to 4-9% of total revenue); Shop Ads (most successful sellers spend 15-25% of revenue); content production ($2,000-$10,000 a month for regular video output); returns and chargebacks (fashion 10-20%, beauty 5-10%, home goods 3-8%) and operational overhead.

Module: Amazon

Data source: Amazon's Selling Partner API (SP-API) for orders, settlements, and fee reports, plus manual inputs for ad spend and return costs where no API field exists.

Fee layers it tracks: referral fees by category - most categories 15%, electronics 8%, clothing and accessories 17% above $20 (5% under $15, 10% from $15-$20), grocery 8-15%, jewellery 20% on the portion up to $250 and 5% above; FBA fulfilment fees by size tier and weight (small standard from about $3.06-$3.86 per unit, large standard roughly $4.08-$9.73, oversize higher); monthly storage fees ($0.78-$0.87 per cubic foot January-September, $2.40 in October-December); aged-inventory surcharges for stock held 181 days or more; inbound placement fees ($0.21-$0.68 per unit for distributed shipments); the 3.5% fuel and logistics surcharge on FBA fulfilment fees in effect from April 2026; Sponsored Products ad spend; and returns, tracked per SKU so a high-return product stops looking like a winner.

Module: Etsy

Data source: the Etsy API for orders and payment-account data, plus seller-entered shipping and ad costs.

Fee layers it tracks: listing fee of $0.20 per listing (charged on creation, renewal, and each sale of a multi-quantity listing); transaction fee of 6.5% on item price plus shipping and gift wrap; payment

processing (US: 3% + $0.25 per order; UK: 4% + £0.20; EU: 4% + EUR 0.30; rates vary by country); Offsite Ads fee of 15% on attributed sales for shops under $10,000 a year, or 12% above that, capped at $100 per order; Etsy Ads spend (seller-set daily budget, pay per click); currency conversion of 2.5% where listing and payout currencies differ; and regulatory operating fees in selected countries (UK 0.48%, France 1.14%, Italy 0.80%, Spain 0.88%, and others).

Module: eBay

Data source: eBay's developer APIs for orders, fees, and advertising reports, plus seller-entered shipping costs.

Fee layers it tracks: final value fee on the total amount the buyer pays - for most categories on eBay.com, 13.6% on the portion up to $7,500 and 2.35% above it (category rates vary: clothing around 15.3%, books and media around 14.6%, electronics around 8-11%, guitars around 6.7%); per-order fee of $0.30 for orders up to $10 and $0.40 above $10; insertion fees (first 250 listings a month free, then $0.35 per listing in most categories); Promoted Listings ad rates, typically 2-20% of the sale, paid only when an attributed sale follows a click within 30 days; international fee of 1.65% on sales outside the US; and the seller's Store subscription tier, which lowers final value fees (Basic around 12.7% in most categories versus 13.6% without a store).

3. The Four Fee Stacks

Each marketplace hides a different part of the stack. Here is what the calculator sees on each one, with verified figures.

TikTok Shop - the full worked example

Taken from Darkroom Agency's 2026 TikTok Shop fee breakdown for a fashion brand doing $50,000 a month (1,250 orders at a $40 average order value). Fashion is used because its 8% referral rate shows the maximum-cost case.

Cost layer	Amount
Referral fee (8%)	$4,000
Transaction fees ($0.30 × 1,250 orders)	$375
Payment processing (2.0%)	$1,000
Shipping and fulfilment (~10%)	$5,000
Affiliate commissions (~10% blended)	$5,000
TikTok Shop Ads (~20%)	$10,000
Content production	$4,000
Returns and chargebacks (~5%)	$2,500
Operational overhead	$2,000
Total selling costs	$33,875 (67.75% of revenue)

That leaves $16,125 to cover the cost of goods. At a 30% product cost ($15,000), the seller is left with **$1,125 profit on $50,000 of revenue - a 2.25% net margin**.

The visible platform fees (referral + transaction + processing) are only $5,375, or 10.75%. The other $28,500 - ads, affiliates, shipping, content, returns, operations - is the part no single dashboard shows. That is the fee stack.

Amazon - the published per-order example

A published 2026 worked example for a $29.99 kitchen gadget on FBA (1.5 lb, Home & Kitchen at 15% referral):

Cost layer	Amount
Referral fee (15%)	$4.50
FBA fulfilment fee (large standard, 1.5 lb)	~$4.75
Fuel and logistics surcharge (3.5% of fulfilment)	~$0.17
Monthly storage (small item)	~$0.15
Total Amazon fees on the order	~$9.57 (about 32% of the price)

That is before product cost, before Sponsored Products ad spend, and before returns. Amazon's stack is dominated by two layers most calculators underweight: the referral fee, which is 15% in most categories, and the per-unit fulfilment fee, which runs $3-$10 or more depending on size and weight - plus storage that triples in Q4 and the 2026 fuel surcharge layered on top of fulfilment.

Etsy - the published per-order example

A published 2026 worked example for a $30 item with free shipping, US seller, no ads:

Cost layer	Amount
Listing fee	$0.20
Transaction fee (6.5%)	$1.95
Payment processing (3% + $0.25)	$1.15
Total Etsy fees	$3.30 (11% of the order)

If that same sale comes through an Offsite Ad at 15%, another $4.50 goes to Etsy and the total becomes $7.80 - 26% of the order. Etsy's headline fee looks small, which is exactly why sellers underestimate it: the transaction fee applies to shipping too, the processing fee applies to the full order total including tax, and a single Offsite Ad sale can more than double the fee on that order.

eBay - illustrative arithmetic from published rates

Using eBay.com's published 2026 rates for a $50 sale in a typical category (illustrative arithmetic from the published rates, not a real seller's case):

Cost layer	Amount
Final value fee (13.6%)	$6.80
Per-order fee	$0.40
Total eBay fees	$7.20 (14.4% of the sale)
With a 5% Promoted Listings ad rate added	+$2.50 -> $9.70 (19.4%)

eBay's trap is different from the others: the final value fee is charged on the whole amount the buyer pays, including shipping and sales tax, so a listing with paid shipping costs more in fees than the item price suggests - and the small-looking $0.40 per-order fee is another 4% on a $10 item. Payment processing is folded into the final value fee under managed payments, so sellers who add a separate processing cut on top double-count it - one more way a partial calculator misleads.

The multi-marketplace picture

Put the four stacks side by side and the pattern is obvious: every marketplace advertises a low headline fee and collects the real money elsewhere - TikTok in ads and affiliates, Amazon in fulfilment

and storage, Etsy in transaction-plus-advertising, eBay in a final value fee charged on shipping and tax too. A seller on two or three of these platforms is not facing one fee stack but three, in three dashboards, in three currencies of confusion. The calculator's job is to put all three on one screen, in the same model, so the seller finally sees the whole picture.

4. Why This Matters: Margin Before Pricing Changes Every Decision

A seller who knows true margin before pricing makes different decisions in six places:

- **Pricing:** products are priced to cover the full stack, not the headline fee - so a rate change (like TikTok's 2% new-seller rate jumping to the standard rate after 90 days) is planned from day one, not discovered as a shock.
- **Product selection:** SKUs that look profitable on revenue but lose money after returns and content costs get dropped before the next stock order.
- **Creator and ad deals:** affiliate rates and ad budgets are negotiated against the blended cost per order, not against hope - a 20% commission is fine on a high-margin SKU and fatal on a thin one, and an ad campaign whose ROAS cannot cover true margin gets paused before it burns cash.
- **Marketplace allocation:** when the same product sells on two platforms, the dashboard shows which platform actually keeps more per order - so the next batch of stock goes where the margin is, not where the revenue looks biggest.
- **Growth timing:** scaling a shop that keeps 2.25% is scaling a loss. The calculator tells the seller when the unit economics actually support growth - and when to fix pricing first.
- **Fee-change readiness:** when a platform changes a fee (a new surcharge, a storage hike, an ads attribution change), the seller sees the effect on margin the same day, instead of at the end of the quarter.

The pattern I see again and again in my client work: the businesses that struggle are not the ones with low sales. They are the ones pricing blind. The fix is not working harder; it is seeing the full stack before deciding.

5. Business Impact, With the Math

Back to the TikTok worked example: $50,000 a month, $33,875 in selling costs, $15,000 in product cost, **$1,125 profit - a 2.25% margin**.

What changes when the seller reprices with the calculator - an illustrative scenario (not a real client's result):

Same $50,000 month, same volume. The calculator flags two things: several SKUs priced below their true cost, and ad spend running at 20% with no margin check. The seller acts on both:

- **Repricing:** raising the average order value by $2 on the flagged SKUs (a 5% price correction) adds $2,500 of revenue at almost no extra cost, because the fee layers are mostly percentage-based and the volume holds.
- **Ad discipline:** trimming ad spend from 20% to 17% of revenue by pausing campaigns whose ROAS cannot cover true margin saves $1,500.

Profit moves from $1,125 to $5,125 - a 10.25% margin on the same $50,000 month. No new products, no extra volume, no extra hours. The only change is that pricing and ad decisions were made with the

full stack visible first.

That is the business impact of the calculator: it does not create sales. It stops a seller from giving away the sales they already have. And on Amazon, Etsy, or eBay, the same logic applies - the numbers change, the leak is the same: a price set from a partial fee picture.

6. Build Roadmap: How I Am Building It, Step by Step

This is the roadmap I am following as I build this app for an agency. It uses vibe-coding tools, so the build is fast and the agency is involved at every step - no technical background needed on their side.

Step 1 - Write the prompt (the spec).

Start with a prompt template that describes the app in plain language: "A dashboard for a marketplace seller that imports order fees from TikTok Shop, Amazon, Etsy, and eBay, adds shipping, affiliate, ad, and return costs per order, and shows true profit per SKU, per marketplace, and per month, with a price simulator that warns when a proposed price loses money." Paste this into your chosen builder and refine the output. The prompt is the spec - the clearer it is, the closer the first version lands.

Step 2 - Pick the builder.

Build the front end and dashboard with one of the vibe-coding platforms:

- v0 - fastest for polished dashboards from a prompt.
- Lovable - strong for full apps with data views and user accounts.
- Bolt - good for a working prototype in a single session.
- Replit - best if you want the code, hosting, and database in one place.

Step 3 - Build the shared core first, then one marketplace adapter at a time.

This is the architecture decision that makes the multi-marketplace version workable: one cost model, one dashboard, one price simulator - and a separate fee adapter per marketplace that translates that platform's fees into the shared model. Start with the marketplace the seller earns most on, verify the adapter against one real statement, then add the next marketplace. Never build all four adapters at once and hope they reconcile.

Step 4 - Connect the data.

Wire in the real numbers per marketplace:

- **TikTok Shop:** partner and seller APIs for orders, fees, and settlements - see the TikTok Shop developer documentation - plus manual inputs for shipping contracts, affiliate rates, ad spend, and return costs where no API exists.
- **Amazon:** the Selling Partner API (SP-API) for orders, settlements, and fee reports; Sponsored Products spend and return costs come in as scheduled inputs.
- **Etsy:** the Etsy API for orders and payment-account data; shipping, Etsy Ads, and Offsite Ads attribution come in as scheduled inputs.
- **eBay:** eBay's developer APIs for orders, fees, and advertising reports; shipping costs come in as seller inputs.

Start with one data source (order fees on the first marketplace), verify it matches a real statement, then add the next layer.

Step 5 - Build the price simulator.

This is the feature that makes the app a decision tool instead of a report: enter a proposed price and a marketplace, and the app runs that marketplace's full stack against it and returns profit per order. Test it against three real SKUs with known costs before trusting it on the whole catalogue.

Step 6 - Deploy it.

Ship the app on Vercel or Netlify - both deploy from a repository in minutes, both give the seller a live link they can open on their phone, and both scale from one user to a team without a rebuild.

Step 7 - Run it for one month beside the old method.

Keep the old spreadsheet (or the old calculator) running in parallel for the first month. At month end, compare: the calculator's margin figure against the actual payout, per marketplace. If they match within a few percent, the old method retires. If they don't, the gap is a missing cost layer - find it, add it, and the model gets stronger.

7. Checklist: Launch the Fee-Stack Calculator Across Your Marketplaces

- [ ] For each marketplace you sell on, list every fee layer: TikTok Shop (referral, transaction, processing, shipping, affiliate, ads, content, returns, operations); Amazon (referral, FBA fulfilment, storage, inbound placement, fuel surcharge, PPC, returns); Etsy (listing, transaction, processing, Offsite Ads, Etsy Ads, conversion, regulatory); eBay (final value, per-order, insertion, Promoted Listings, international).
- [ ] Pull one real month's statement per marketplace and total the visible platform fees - then total everything else. Compare the two numbers, per marketplace.
- [ ] Identify your three highest-volume SKUs and compute true profit per order for each, returns included, on each marketplace they sell on.
- [ ] Flag every SKU priced below its true cost on any marketplace - these are the first repricing candidates.
- [ ] Set affiliate rates and ad budgets against blended cost per order and true margin, not against revenue.
- [ ] Check every ad campaign's ROAS against true margin, not revenue - pause anything that cannot cover it.
- [ ] Compare the same SKU's true margin across marketplaces - shift stock toward the platform that keeps more per order.
- [ ] Run the price simulator on every new listing, on every marketplace, before it goes live.
- [ ] Revisit the dashboard weekly: fees change, ad costs drift, return rates move with the season, and platforms add surcharges without asking.

8. The Blueprint I Am Working From

This guide is the blueprint on which I am working as I am building the Fee-Stack Calculator for an agency: the prompt template, the multi-marketplace adapter architecture, the data-connection steps, and the dashboard layout, all in one place. Everything in it is written to be used, not just read - work through the checklist in section 7 against your own shop's numbers, and the fee stack stops being invisible.

*Sources for the fee figures in this guide: Darkroom Agency, "TikTok Shop Fees 2026: Complete

Seller Cost Breakdown" - https://www.darkroomagency.com/observatory/tiktok-shop-fees-seller-cost-breakdown-2026 · Amazon fee figures: YieldCalcHub, "Amazon FBA Fees 2026" - https://www.yieldcalchub.com/guides/amazon-fba-fees/ and FeeCalculator.pro - https://feecalculator.pro/amazon-fba-fees-2026/ · Etsy fee figures: The Design Hippo, "Etsy Fee Calculator" - https://www.thedesignhippo.com/etsy-fee-calculator/ and "How Much Does Etsy Take From a $30 Sale? (2026 Fee Breakdown)" - https://nidhi69n.medium.com/how-much-does-etsy-take-from-a-30-sale-2026-fee-breakdown-4dae978e34b0 · eBay fee figures: Size.ly, "eBay Fee Calculator" (source: eBay official fee schedule, verified 16 Oct 2026) - https://www.size.ly/tools/ebay-fee-calculator and 3DSellers, "eBay Fee Calculator 2026" - https://www.3dsellers.com/fee-calculators/us-ebay-fee-calculator*

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